Design brief

Steam reviews of ELEX, a single-player open-world action role-playing game. Generated by the review pipeline on 1,200 reviews, 2026-11-10. Draft for review by the design team.

In short. To enhance player satisfaction, the game should first address combat dynamics **R1**, movement and evasion **R2**, and enemy strength and balance **R3** to ensure responsive and balanced gameplay. It is crucial to maintain the early game difficulty **A1** and overall difficulty **A2** as they contribute positively to player mastery and challenge. Additionally, the game should preserve elements like story engagement **P1**, world building **P2**, and factions and lore **P3** to maintain immersion and player engagement.

Priorities

Repair first criticized, and goes with a worse outcome. **Accepted friction** criticized, yet goes with a better outcome: keep it. **Protect** praised, and goes with a better outcome: preserve it. Outcome: recommending the game.

ID	Aspect	Requirement	Reviews
R1	Combat Dynamics	The game must refine combat mechanics to ensure responsive and fluid interactions, reducing clunkiness and improving player satisfaction.	536
R2	Movement and Evasion	The game must improve movement responsiveness and reduce animation delays for actions like dodging and jetpacking.	163
R3	Enemy Strength and Balance	The game must adjust enemy damage output to ensure player health is not depleted by a single hit from evenly-matched enemies.	132
R4	Performance and Technical Implementation	The game must optimize performance to reduce lag and improve frame rates across all platforms.	55
R5	Control and Customization	The game must allow full customization of keybinds, including the 'E' key and weapon switching controls.	39
R6	Crash and Stability	The game must ensure stability by preventing crashes and freezes during gameplay, especially during key sequences and dialogues.	36
A1	Early Game Difficulty	Keep the early game difficulty as a core challenge, ensuring players understand its role in character development and progression.	177
A2	Overall Difficulty and Mastery	Keep the high difficulty level but improve communication about its role in player mastery and challenge.	165
P1	Story Engagement	Preserve the impact of player choices on story progression and quest outcomes.	250
P2	World Building	Preserve the immersive and unique blend of sci-fi, fantasy, and post-apocalyptic elements in the game world.	162
P3	Factions and Lore	Preserve the distinctiveness and moral ambiguity of each faction to maintain player immersion and engagement.	144
P4	Exploration and Resource Management	Preserve the rewarding nature of exploration by ensuring players consistently find new items, weapons, and events.	140
P5	Character Growth and Replayability	Preserve the sense of character progression and replayability by ensuring varied character growth paths and multiple playthrough options.	85
P6	Gameplay Duration and Engagement	Preserve the sense of progression and engagement by ensuring that player skills and abilities continue to develop meaningfully over time.	69

Tensions to resolve

A change that repairs one aspect may weaken another that players value. Each candidate pair in the same area of the game was checked; only direct conflicts are listed.

- **Repair R3** (Enemy Strength and Balance) vs **Keep A1** (Early Game Difficulty)
  If the team reduces enemy damage, then the early game difficulty may be weakened, affecting character development and progression. *Watch:* Monitor player feedback on early game challenge and character growth in later reviews.
- **Repair R3** (Enemy Strength and Balance) vs **Keep A2** (Overall Difficulty and Mastery)
  If the team reduces enemy damage, then the overall difficulty level may be perceived as lower, affecting player mastery and challenge. *Watch:* Monitor player feedback on difficulty and challenge in later reviews.

Requirements

R1 Combat Dynamics — **Repair first**

The game must refine combat mechanics to ensure responsive and fluid interactions, reducing clunkiness and improving player satisfaction.

Why. Players experience combat as clunky, unpolished, and unenjoyable, detracting from overall game immersion.

Mentioned in 536 of 1,200 reviews (45%); 68% of comments negative, 21% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 53% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are less likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 0.62, 95% CI 0.48–0.79).

Players say.

- *"the combat mechanics are clunky"*
- *"The combat mechanics can feel clunky and unpolished at times"*

Possible change. Enhance combat responsiveness by optimizing input detection, balancing stamina usage, and refining enemy AI to provide a more fluid and engaging combat experience.

Check after the change. Post-change reviews should indicate improved combat fluidity, responsiveness, and enjoyment, with fewer mentions of clunkiness or frustration.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

R2 Movement and Evasion — **Repair first**

The game must improve movement responsiveness and reduce animation delays for actions like dodging and jetpacking.

Why. Players experience unresponsive controls and delayed animations, making evasion and movement frustrating.

Mentioned in 163 of 1,200 reviews (14%); 49% of comments negative, 37% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 33% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are less likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 0.56, 95% CI 0.40–0.79).

Players say.

- *"The control responsiveness is terrible: saves that work intermittently, attacks that don't trigger on time, and elixirs disappearing due to enemies interrupting animations."* (translated from russian)
- *"You press space to fly with the backpack, but the character first completes all combat animations, then tries to fly."* (translated from russian)

Possible change. Optimize control responsiveness and streamline animations for dodging, jetpacking, and other movement actions.

Check after the change. Reviews should indicate smoother movement and more responsive controls, with fewer complaints about animation delays.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

R3 Enemy Strength and Balance — **Repair first**

The game must adjust enemy damage output to ensure player health is not depleted by a single hit from evenly-matched enemies.

Why. Players experience frustration from being one-hit KO'd by enemies, disrupting gameplay balance.

Mentioned in 132 of 1,200 reviews (11%); 89% of comments negative, 6% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 50% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are less likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 0.47, 95% CI 0.32–0.68).

Players say.

- *"98% of the enemies will 1 SHOT YOU"*
- *"a single hit from any evenly-matched enemy will scythe down a huge chunk of your health"*

Possible change. Reduce the damage dealt by enemies to allow players to survive multiple hits, enhancing survivability and balance.

Check after the change. Reviews should indicate improved player survivability and balanced encounters, with fewer complaints about one-hit deaths.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

R4 Performance and Technical Implementation **Repair first**

The game must optimize performance to reduce lag and improve frame rates across all platforms.

Why. Players experience significant lag and poor frame rates, affecting gameplay and enjoyment.

Mentioned in 55 of 1,200 reviews (5%); 69% of comments negative, 30% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 40% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are less likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 0.50, 95% CI 0.29–0.85).

Players say.

- *"lacking QA and playtesting"*
- *"It's not that stable of a game and not well optimized yet"*

Possible change. Enhance the game's engine to optimize resource management, reduce loading times, and improve frame rate stability.

Check after the change. Reviews should indicate smoother gameplay, reduced lag, and improved frame rates, with fewer technical issues.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

R5 Control and Customization **Repair first**

The game must allow full customization of keybinds, including the 'E' key and weapon switching controls.

Why. Players experience frustration with locked keys and clunky controls, affecting gameplay enjoyment.

Mentioned in 39 of 1,200 reviews (3%); 90% of comments negative, 5% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 34% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are less likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 0.29, 95% CI 0.15–0.55).

Players say.

- *"The 'E' key is 'locked' ... so I can't change that to move forward and remap its competing key"*
- *"Keybinds are NOT fully customizable"*

Possible change. Implement a fully customizable keybinding system, allowing players to remap all controls, including weapon switching and movement.

Check after the change. Reviews should indicate improved control satisfaction and mention the ability to customize keybinds.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

R6 Crash and Stability **Repair first**

The game must ensure stability by preventing crashes and freezes during gameplay, especially during key sequences and dialogues.

Why. Players experience frequent crashes and freezes, disrupting gameplay and causing frustration.

Mentioned in 36 of 1,200 reviews (3%); 75% of comments negative, 20% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 35% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are less likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 0.42, 95% CI 0.22–0.80).

Players say.

- *"The only way to fix it is to restart the game"*
- *"In the final scene of the game, near the climax, the game crashed with an error and froze."* (translated from russian)

Possible change. Implement robust error handling and optimize code to prevent crashes during critical game moments and dialogues.

Check after the change. Reviews should indicate a significant reduction in crashes and freezes, with players noting smoother gameplay.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

A1 Early Game Difficulty — **Accepted friction**

Keep the early game difficulty as a core challenge, ensuring players understand its role in character development and progression.

Why. Players value the challenge as it contributes to a rewarding experience and character growth.

Mentioned in 177 of 1,200 reviews (15%); 94% of comments negative, 3% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 77% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are more likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 1.60, 95% CI 1.10–2.34).

Players say.

- *"1st 20hours. hard to overcome, lots of running and skipping till you get right level and gear"*
- *"The game is hard AF"*

Possible change. Enhance communication about the difficulty's purpose, framing it as a deliberate design choice for character development.

Check after the change. Reviews should reflect appreciation for the challenge as a meaningful part of the game's progression.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

A2 Overall Difficulty and Mastery — **Accepted friction**

Keep the high difficulty level but improve communication about its role in player mastery and challenge.

Why. Players value the challenge but find the difficulty frustrating and poorly communicated.

Mentioned in 165 of 1,200 reviews (14%); 55% of comments negative, 32% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 67% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are more likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 1.68, 95% CI 1.14–2.50).

Players say.

- *"This can both create interesting situations that you can exploit, as well as frustration."* (translated from swedish)
- *"There is no challenge here, no mastery"*

Possible change. Introduce in-game tutorials or tips that frame difficulty as a path to mastery, emphasizing strategic play and preparation.

Check after the change. Reviews should reflect appreciation for the challenge and mention improved understanding of difficulty's role in mastery.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

P1 Story Engagement — **Protect**

Preserve the impact of player choices on story progression and quest outcomes.

Why. Players value how their decisions influence the game's narrative and world.

Mentioned in 250 of 1,200 reviews (21%); 21% of comments negative, 72% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 54% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are more likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 2.17, 95% CI 1.54–3.07).

Players say.

- *"in Elex, choices REALLY DO matter"*
- *"Many choices and actions in the game will truly have consequences."* (translated from schinese)

Possible change. Ensure that any modifications to quest mechanics maintain the existing consequence system for player choices.

Check after the change. Post-change reviews should continue to highlight the meaningful impact of choices on the story and quests.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

P2 World Building **Protect**

Preserve the immersive and unique blend of sci-fi, fantasy, and post-apocalyptic elements in the game world.

Why. Players experience a rich, engaging world that feels alive and original, enhancing their connection to the game.

Mentioned in 162 of 1,200 reviews (14%); 15% of comments negative, 70% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 48% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are more likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 1.78, 95% CI 1.19–2.66).

Players say.

- *"It's an interesting world - a post-apocalyptic fantasy/sci-fi mashup"*
- *"blends elements of science fiction, fantasy, and post-apocalyptic settings"*

Possible change. Ensure that any modifications maintain the balance of high technology and magic, and the diversity of locations and cultures.

Check after the change. Reviews should continue to highlight the world's creativity, depth, and the seamless integration of different thematic elements.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

P3 Factions and Lore **Protect**

Preserve the distinctiveness and moral ambiguity of each faction to maintain player immersion and engagement.

Why. Players enjoy the unique characteristics and moral complexities of each faction, enhancing immersion.

Mentioned in 144 of 1,200 reviews (12%); 22% of comments negative, 50% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 62% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are more likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 1.88, 95% CI 1.22–2.88).

Players say.

- *"Love the faction system and the moral ambiguity everywhere"*
- *"The medieval Berserkers who wish to heal the planet, the Outlaws, with their thievery, lack of trust, and the variety of modern weapons and explosives, and the Clerics, a more futuristic faction utilising plasma and laser weapons, followers of their own god"*

Possible change. Ensure that any modifications to faction narratives or abilities maintain their unique identities and moral dilemmas.

Check after the change. Post-change reviews should continue to highlight the distinctiveness and moral complexity of factions without negative feedback.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

P4 Exploration and Resource Management **Protect**

Preserve the rewarding nature of exploration by ensuring players consistently find new items, weapons, and events.

Why. Players enjoy discovering new elements and feel rewarded for exploring the game world.

Mentioned in 140 of 1,200 reviews (12%); 30% of comments negative, 48% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 68% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are more likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 2.62, 95% CI 1.62–4.21).

Players say.

- *"Just running around and looking around every corner will let you discover new items, weapons and events"*
- *"Exploration in this game is outstanding, with interesting places to explore all over the map"*

Possible change. Ensure that exploration consistently yields new discoveries, such as items and events, to maintain player engagement.

Check after the change. Reviews should indicate that exploration continues to feel rewarding and leads to new discoveries.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

P5 Character Growth and Replayability **Protect**

Preserve the sense of character progression and replayability by ensuring varied character growth paths and multiple playthrough options.

Why. Players experience satisfaction from character growth and enjoy replaying the game with different outcomes.

Mentioned in 85 of 1,200 reviews (7%); 10% of comments negative, 85% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 50% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are more likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 5.69, 95% CI 2.53–12.79).

Players say.

- *"Roleplaying aspect and replayability is strong in this game"*
- *"Elex does a GREAT job of letting you feel the growth of your character"*

Possible change. Verify that character progression remains diverse and that multiple playthroughs offer distinct experiences.

Check after the change. Reviews should continue to highlight varied character growth and multiple playthroughs without diminishing satisfaction.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

P6 Gameplay Duration and Engagement **Protect**

Preserve the sense of progression and engagement by ensuring that player skills and abilities continue to develop meaningfully over time.

Why. Players experience a rewarding journey as their skills grow, making previously challenging encounters easier.

Mentioned in 69 of 1,200 reviews (6%); 27% of comments negative, 62% positive. Of the players who criticize it, 58% end up recommending the game (all players: 70%). Reviews that mention it are more likely to be recommending the game (odds ratio 2.27, 95% CI 1.19–4.33).

Players say.

- *"Previously impossible fights gradually become easier as you, and your skills, progress"*
- *"After about 12h of suffering you will be able to finally enjoy the game by wrecking almost every NPC and visiting almost every place on the map since there are no restrictions except the final showdown"*

Possible change. Hypothesize that maintaining a balanced difficulty curve and skill progression will sustain player engagement.

Check after the change. Reviews should indicate that players feel challenged yet capable, with a sense of growth and accomplishment.

Decision: ☐ Accept ☐ Modify ☐ Reject Notes: _____

Often criticized, but not decisive

These aspects have more negative than positive extracts but no significant link with the outcome. The reviews give no reason to put them first.

Aspect	Reviews	Negative	Odds ratio
Graphics Quality	184	46%	1.00
Progression Speed and Reward Balance	157	64%	0.69
Character Progression	128	52%	0.93
Difficulty Curve and Scaling	117	71%	0.71
Bug Impact Spectrum	113	91%	0.90
Combat Challenge	79	83%	0.57

About this brief

Numbers and quotes are computed from the coded reviews; quotes are verbatim, and translations into English are marked. Requirements, reasons, changes, the summary and the tensions are drafts written by a language model and are hypotheses: the associations are not causal and no change has been tested. Groups: a sub-theme is a priority when its odds ratio differs from 1 after Benjamini–Hochberg correction; its tone is the balance of negative and positive extracts. The source of every number and quote is in design_brief.json.